Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

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THE DANCE OF THE LEATHER PUPPETS



Tholu Bommalata, literally meaning “leather puppet dance”, is the ancient shadow puppetry tradition from Andhra Pradesh that dates back to 200 BCE.

Practiced as a hereditary craft by the Marathi Balija community in Nimmalakunta village, this art form received a GI tag in 2008.



Historically, it served as both a spiritual medium and a tool for social education, narrating episodes from the Ramayana and the Mahabharata. The iconic characters were brought to life through the play of shadow and light created by deftly moving the puppets with strings and sticks.



Performances were believed to bring prosperity and rain, and featured troupes of puppeteers manipulating figures behind a backlit screen, singing verses and accompanied by the sounds of the mridangam and harmonium. Lamps were arranged around the screen in such a way that the size and position of the puppets changed with distance from the lights.



Goat hides and sheep skins form the base material. The hides are subjected to hot water treatment to make them soft. Following this initial cleaning, the leather undergoes another soaking with kadaka powder, introducing a subtle light brown hue. Smoothed leather is washed several times until it becomes like transparent paper and serves as the canvas for puppet designs.



The creation of these puppets is a long process of 30-40 days.

Artisans sketch intricate designs, outlining them with bamboo nibs using a mix of lamp black and tree gum. Design motifs draw inspiration from traditional and religious sources, featuring Hindu deities, Panchatantra characters, animals, birds and flora.

Vibrant vegetable dyes and synthetic colours are applied to the leather, with specific colours signifying different characters.



To enhance the visual impact, artisans perform the ‘grooving’. Round perforations are made to accentuate the effect of light in the background.

After painting the components, the figures are cut out and the assembled puppet is created by sewing the cut pieces together. Limbs are made separately and then stitched with the body to ensure the puppets remain flexible enough to manoeuvre the arms and legs.

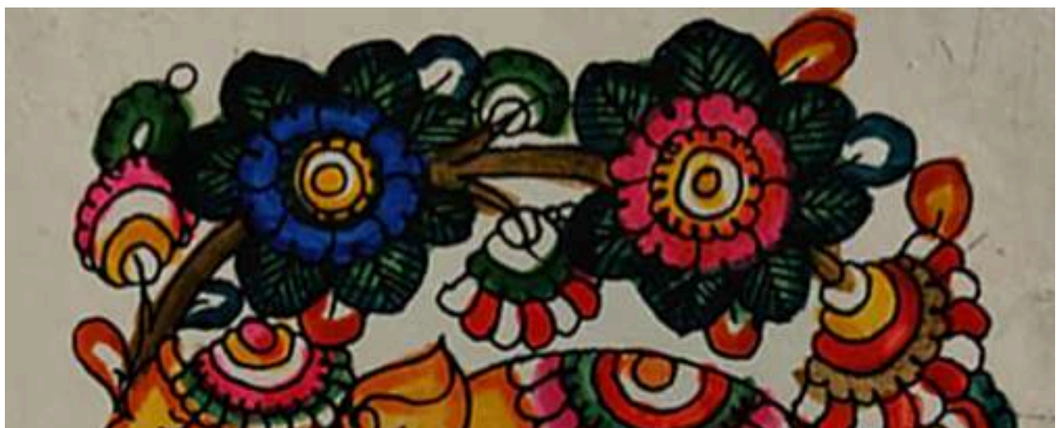


Despite its rich heritage, the rise of cinema and television led to a decline in traditional shadow theatre. To preserve their livelihood, the artisans have successfully pivoted towards the modern market.



With help from the Andhra Pradesh government and design interventions from NIFT, the community now produces functional items like lampshades, fairy lights, wall clocks, wall-mounted puppets and jewellery. These contemporary pieces retain the essence of traditional craftsmanship while ensuring that the legacy of Tholu Bommalata survives in modern homes.









CREDITS

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